5-Minute Small Business Cybersecurity Checklist

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Tick each box that is true for your whole business today, not just for you. Every empty box is a gap an attacker can use, and the 28 boxes below take about five minutes.

Business: _____ Date: _____ Completed by: _____

1. Accounts and passwords (1 minute)

- [ ] Every person has a unique password for each work account, with no reuse.
- [ ] A business password manager is in use, not sticky notes, spreadsheets or browser notes.
- [ ] Multi-factor authentication (MFA) is on for email, banking, accounting and cloud storage, using an authenticator app where possible.
- [ ] Admin rights are limited to the people who need them, and admins use a separate account for daily work.
- [ ] Accounts of former staff and contractors have been disabled.

2. Email and phishing (1 minute)

- [ ] Spam and phishing filtering is turned on for business email.
- [ ] Staff know to check the sender and hover over links before clicking.
- [ ] Payment or banking-detail change requests are confirmed by phone, using a number you already have.
- [ ] Staff have one simple way to report a suspicious email, such as forwarding it to a named person.
- [ ] Staff have had security awareness training in the past 12 months.

3. Devices and updates (1 minute)

- [ ] Operating systems and apps update automatically on every computer and phone that touches business data.

- [ ] Security software, at minimum Microsoft Defender or equivalent, is active on every computer.
- [ ] Laptops and phones are encrypted (BitLocker, FileVault or device encryption) and lock automatically within 5 minutes.
- [ ] No device runs an operating system that no longer receives security updates.
- [ ] You have a list of every device that connects to business data.

4. Backups and data (1 minute)

- [ ] Critical business data is backed up automatically at least once a day.
- [ ] You follow the 3-2-1 rule: 3 copies, on 2 types of storage, with 1 copy offsite or offline.
- [ ] You have restored a file from backup in the past 6 months to prove it works.
- [ ] You know where customer and employee personal information is stored.

5. Network and Wi-Fi (30 seconds)

- [ ] The default admin password on your router or firewall has been changed, and its firmware is current.
- [ ] Guests and smart devices (cameras, printers, TVs) use a separate network from business computers.
- [ ] Wi-Fi uses WPA2 or WPA3 with a long passphrase that is changed when staff leave.
- [ ] Remote access to the office is limited to a VPN or an MFA-protected tool, and router remote administration is off.

6. People and response plan (1 minute)

- [ ] One person is named responsible for security and knows your privacy-breach reporting duties.
- [ ] Staff can open only the files and systems their role needs.
- [ ] A one-page "if we are hacked" plan lists who to call first, such as your IT provider, bank and cyber insurer.
- [ ] Those emergency contacts are also kept on paper or offline, in case email is down.
- [ ] Staff know to report a suspected incident right away and to disconnect the affected device from the network.

Your score: ____ out of 28

Boxes ticked	What it means	Next step
24 to 28	Strong foundation	Review every 6 months and test your backups
16 to 23	Gaps attackers can use	Fix the unchecked items in sections 1, 2 and 4 first
0 to 15	High risk	Start with MFA, backups and updates this week

Need help closing the gaps? MaZen IT Solutions provides managed IT and cybersecurity for small businesses. Visit www.mazenitsolutions.ca to get in touch.

This checklist is general guidance and is not a full security assessment.